

Policing Irregularities: How Barcelona Reproduces Global Crimmigration Narratives

RIMC10: Global discourse and narratives of crime

Ainhoa Zamora Martínez

Student number: 692678

Word Count: 2486

Supervisor: Dr. Abdessamad Bouabid

International Master in Advanced Research in Criminology (IMARC)

Academic year: 2025 – 2026

1. Introduction

Across Europe, migration governance has increasingly shifted away from external border zones and into everyday spaces of cities. Urban environments have become central sites where migration control is enacted through ordinary policing practices, such as identity checks, patrols in specific neighbourhoods, and public-order operations. This shift reflects broader transformations in governance, in which concerns about security, risk, and social order are addressed through preventive and discretionary forms of control. As a result, immigration enforcement is no longer confined to formal border crossings but is embedded within routine law enforcement, blurring the distinction between crime control and migration management.

This paper investigates the following research question: **How do Barcelona's urban policing practices reflect global narratives that intertwine crimmigration with border control, particularly in framing irregular migrants as threats to security and order?**

This question sits at the intersection of border criminology, urban governance, and migration studies, demanding attention to the ways in which global security is applied in specific local enforcement practices.

This paper adopts a qualitative content analysis using a crimmigration lens (Stumpf, 2006), complemented by framing theory, to analyse how migration control is discursively embedded within urban policing practices. Barcelona offers a compelling case study: a major EU southern border city characterised by multi-level governance tensions between municipal, regional, and national authorities; patterns of racialised police identification; and a detention infrastructure in the *Centro de Internamiento de Extranjeros* (CIE)¹.

Barcelona's policing reflects global crimmigration narratives through three diagnostic frames—danger, disorder, and disease—that construct irregular migrants as threats, legitimised through technocratic depoliticisation and crisis invocation. It also argues that the pandemic enabled both rupture and intensification, exposing the dispensability of detention while facilitating new exclusions.

¹ Detention Centre for Foreigners situated in La Zona Franca.

2. Methodology

This paper employs a qualitative content analysis of secondary sources, informed by framing theory, to examine discursive constructions of crimmigration within urban policing in Barcelona. Rather than treating sources as factual accounts, the approach is to treat them as discursive artefacts that participate in producing narratives that frame irregular migrants in different ways. The corpus consists of 22 sources, spanning 2006-2025, comprising 13 peer-reviewed journal articles, 2 academic monographs, 4 NGO reports, 1 think-tank analysis, and 2 policy-oriented digital publications (grey literature). These were gathered via Scopus, JSTOR and Google Scholar.

Coding followed a primarily deductive logic, guided by framing theory and crimmigration scholarship, while it also used inductive emergent frames across coding rounds. This method allows theory-driven coding while accommodating emergent themes, ensuring critical reflections on all narratives (Assarroudi et al., 2018). Analysis was organised through two rounds: First-round coding identified diagnostic frames (how problems are defined, who is constructed as a threat) and prognostic frames (proposed solutions). Second-round coding examined frame convergence across source types—suggesting hegemony—and divergences revealing controversy.

This approach was chosen because it allows for systematic identification of recurring discursive frames across heterogeneous textual sources, treating them as discursive artefacts participating in the constructions of the phenomena they describe. The methodology's limitation is reliance on secondary sources rather than primary fieldwork; however, triangulation across source types strengthens validity. The value of this methodology lies in its ability to uncover policy-relevant silences in crimmigration discourses.

3. Discussion

Building on the analysis, this section applies framing theory to dissect diagnostic and prognostic elements, critically reflecting on how secondary sources reveal policy silences. Situating Barcelona's policing practices within the broader theoretical landscape requires engagement with global narratives of crime that increasingly frame migration as a security problem warranting penal intervention. This trend reflects what Franko (2012) describes

as the geopolitical division of criminological knowledge, whereby theories developed in the Global North are often treated as universally applicable, while the lived realities of border zones, port cities, and sites of transit remain marginalised. Challenging this assumption, Southern Criminology foregrounds how crime control operates differently in spaces shaped by colonial legacies, economic dependency, and geopolitical asymmetries (Carrington et al., 2016).

Barcelona, as a Southern European port city and EU border, occupies an ambivalent position within this global order, simultaneously enforcing Global North security logics into local practices, contending with their destabilising effects. This makes it a revealing site for examining how global crimmigration narratives are translated into urban policing practices, which include identity checks in public spaces, patrols in racialised neighbourhoods, and the discretionary use of public order powers by municipal and regional police.

Crimmigration theory further elucidates the fusion of criminal and immigration law, positioning migrants as outsiders subject to heightened sovereign control and exclusion (Stumpf, 2006). In Barcelona, this convergence is not merely legal but deeply discursive; administrative infractions, including lacking a residency permit, are treated with punitive intensity, reinforcing a global narrative of the migrant as an inherent security threat. This crimmigration is further reflected in what Kalir (2023) showed on how police interpret policies expansively, transforming routine irregularities into crimmigration, strengthening overall governance of illegalised migrants as a security matter.

Central to this, Franko (2020) calls the “*crimmigrant other*”. This is not a category of person that the law simply finds, but a subject position created through the intersection of migrant control and penal power. In Barcelona, *crimmigrant other* emerges through accumulated discursive and institutional practices that mark certain individuals as suspect, dangerous, and excludable. Consequently, the analytical task of this paper is not to determine if migrants are *actually* threats, but to examine how these threat constructions are produced and naturalised. This is often achieved through what Moffette (2020) terms “intralegal jurisdictional games”, where different police forces in Barcelona (*Guardia Urbana*, *Mossos d’Esquadra*, and *Policia Nacional*) navigate overlapping legal regimes to justify enforcement. For instance, a stop-and-search might be framed as a public order

issue to bypass municipal limitations on immigration enforcement, a key legitimization strategy examined in the findings below.

Furthermore, these local ‘games’ are fuelled by a broader European political climate. Far right and mainstream actors alike have reinforced these narratives by portraying migrants as threats to physical security and cultural cohesion (Bazurli & Catelli, 2025). During the pandemic, this global discourse added a new dimension: migrants were framed as potential carriers of disease and “vectors of disorder” (Tsiganou et al., 2021). And to bridge the gap between these broad crimmigration theories and the specific reality of Barcelona, this paper uses Framing Theory as a methodological link. It will identify diagnostic frames—which define the “migrant problem” in specific ways—we can see exactly how global narratives of danger, disorder, and disease materialise in local policing.

3.1. Diagnostic Frames: Constructing the Migrant

After the analysis, three diagnostic frames emerged across the corpus:

The danger frame

This frame constructs irregular migrants as inherent security threats, legitimising intensified policing despite the absence of criminal conduct. Kalir’s (2023) ethnographic research with Spain’s Brigade of Aliens and Borders documents officers describing irregular migrants as “dangerous delinquents” regardless of criminal records. The category of “qualified expulsions”—ostensibly targeting migrants with criminal histories—expanded to encompass those with purely administrative violations, revealing categorical deficit: irregular status functions as proxy for criminality.

The SJM (2023) report reproduces official justifications framing CIE detention as protecting society, while providing contradicting data: 71% of detentions stem from expulsion orders rather than criminal proceedings; 57% of detainees are released without deportation. Other criminological studies, confirm that the frame operated through racial proxies. Ziati et al.’s (2021) survey reveals ethnic minorities experience disproportionate police stops premised on “suspiciousness” rather than observed conduct. For instance, SOS Racisme Catalunya (2022) documents 602,387 police identifications in Catalonia, with 40% targeted foreign nationals despite comprising 16% of population—a 3.48:1 disproportionality ratio.

This aligns with Weber and McCulloch's (2019) pre-emptive thesis: migrants are policed for anticipated rather than actual harms, presence framed as a risk requiring surveillance. This frame produces Franko's *crimmigrant other* not through criminality, but through threat attributed to racialised bodies—yet racial profiling remains unnameable in official discourse, confirming Van der Woude and Van der Leun's (2017) insight that discretion operated through implicit frames.

Together, these practices demonstrate how the danger frame transforms administrative status into a proxy for criminality within Barcelona's urban policing. Further, it mirrors Bauman's (2016) argument that migrants function as symbolic carriers of insecurity, allowing states to perform sovereignty through visible control of marginalised populations. In this sense, the danger does not merely respond to crime, but it actively produces the migrant as a figure that requires continuous surveillance. This local practice echoes global narratives in the EU's New Pact on Migration and Asylum, where migrants are framed as security threats through mandatory border screening processes that assess risks and enable the suspension of fundamental rights in cases of instrumentalisation—defined as third-country exploitation of migration flows to undermine EU stability (EC, 2024).

The disorder frame

A second frame constructs migrants as threats to public order and urban functionality. SOS Racisme's (2023) analysis documents police identity checks justified through “public order” rationales, obscuring immigration control functions. The Global Detention Project (2020) notes mass identification controls—90,406 in 2011, reduced to 30,306 by 2015 following legal challenges—operated through disorder justifications, courts eventually found pretextual. Notably, Spain was one of the first EU countries to empty all CIEs during COVID, demonstrating detention is not necessary. Other scholars have argued that these centres represent the “most afflictive and repressive tools” of Spanish migration policy; explaining how detention is disproportionately applied despite law requiring it as a “last resort” (SJM, 2024).

Other academics analyse how port cities are spaces where crime control and mobility intersect (Sergi, 2020), this reflects a shift in urban governance, in which migration control is displaced onto local authorities under the guise of maintaining order. Disorder

becomes a flexible category through which border control is enacted without formally invoking or violating immigration law.

The disease frame

Lastly, COVID-19 introduced a third frame constructing migrants as epidemiological threats. Tsiganou et al. (2021) theorise public health as an additive component to crimmigration, documenting intensified controls under sanitary justifications. Bazurli and Castelli (2025) document interview results where they explicitly show constructions and stigmatising migrants as “uncivilised spreaders”.

Furthermore, other sources reveal the frame’s instrumentality: Spain closed border for health reasons while deportation flights to Morocco continued weekly (Statewatch, 2021). Spanish and EU authorities creating an “island cage” at Canary Islands mirroring the Lampedusa model, effectively weaponizing health measures to justify confinement and create a 'legal grey zone' at the border, combined with deportation pressure, representing the EU Pact on Migration being put brutally into practice. This frame further reinforces the concept of pre-emptive state, where the disease exemplifies measures introducing during crises risk becoming normalised, in other words, future risks justifying present exclusion (Weber and McCulloch, 2019).

3.2. Prognostic Frames: Legitimation Strategies and Counter Frames

While diagnostic frames construct migrants as threats, prognostic frames in this paper reveal how crimmigration is sustained and normalised through institutional routines rather than overt repression. By framing detention and deportation as administrative necessities, state actors depoliticise practices that have profound rights implications. Scholars have described this as the expansion of penal power through bureaucratic normalisation, where discretion is exercised without accountability. In this sense, crimmigration becomes self-reinforcing: framed as inevitable, it forecloses political debate about alternative forms of urban inclusion and governance.

Across institutional sources, crimmigration is legitimised through framing presenting enforcement as non-ideological administration. Bazurli and Castelli (2025) identify “pragmatism” and “technocracy” as key frames: border control as practical common

sense, opponents dismiss it as an ideological frame. Additionally, AIDA & ECRE (2025) documents Spanish judges validating detention orders routinely, treating internment as procedures rather than rights intervention, as an “automatic” deprivation of liberty outcome.

A policy analysis of migration policies across crisis periods conceptualises “crisification of migration”—crisis as governance opportunity. This examines the role of private actors in framing migration as a security threat, arguing externalisation and privatisation measures have become normalised everyday policies (Planas, 2024). Furthermore, the CIE Barcelona has become more restrictive, like a “bunkerised area”, with pandemic-era restrictions still in place, where internment is like institutional racism that does not address immigration effectively.

Counter frames and their limits

Counter-discourses appear in activist-aligned sources (Triviño-Salazar, 2020) frames Barcelona as potential “city of refuge”, after its long trajectory of policies to give voice and representations to ensure the rights of immigrants. However, others describe refugee facilities as worse than prisons and as instruments that least respects rights in EU (Saez, 2017).

Moreover, López Sala & Barbero (2019) document solidarity activists contesting criminalisation—yet facing “crimes of solidarity” prosecution, demonstrating counter-discourse becoming an enforcement target. Further, Stumpf’s (2006) membership theory illuminates structural constraints: migration control remains sovereign prerogative; local inclusion claims cannot override. Barcelona’s municipal opposition coexists with CIE’s continued operation under Interior Ministry authority. Counter-discourses achieve visibility without transformation. These counter-frames remain structurally constrained, as municipal inclusion narratives cannot override national sovereignty over migration control.

4. Conclusion

This paper set out to examine how Barcelona’s urban policing practices reflect global narratives that intertwine crimmigration with border control, particularly in the framing of irregular migrants as threats to security and order. The analysis demonstrates that

Barcelona's policing does so by embedding border control within everyday law enforcement through three interlocking diagnostic frames—danger, disorder, and disease. These frames transform irregular legal status into a proxy for criminality, legitimising intensified surveillance, detention, and exclusion. In this sense, Barcelona's urban policing does not simply enforce migration law; it actively produces the "*crimmigrant other*" through routinised, discretionary, and depoliticised mechanisms. Results reveal frame convergences across sources, underscoring hegemony, yet NGO divergences highlight contestation, offering useful insights for my thesis.

Rescaled to the global level, Barcelona should not be understood as an exceptional or deviant case. Rather, it operates as a nodal point within a broader view of global border governance, where migration control is increasingly internalised into urban spaces. As an internal EU border and Southern European port city, Barcelona translates Global North security logics into local practices, while contending with its destabilising social effects.

Theoretically, these findings reinforce Franko's (2019) critique of the geopolitics of criminological knowledge by demonstrating how ostensibly universal crime-control logics obscure their situated effects in border cities. They also underscore the contribution of Southern Criminology, which challenges Northern epistemologies by foregrounding how penal power operates in contexts shaped by geopolitical asymmetry, legal fragmentation, and historical marginalisation. Moreover, the analysis extends Weber & McCulloch (2019) pre-emptive state thesis by showing how health, order, and security rationales converge to justify anticipatory exclusion as a routine feature of urban governance.

Politically, the implications are significant. When crimmigration is framed as technical administration rather than contested policy, democratic accountability in societies is weakened and rights-based alternatives seem to be foreclosed (Stumpf, 2023; Ryo et al., 2025). Municipal claims to inclusion, as Barcelona illustrates, remain structurally constrained by national sovereignty over migration control. To address this tension, it requires not only legal safeguards—such as transparency in identity checks and limits on administrative detention—but also a re-politicisation of migration governance that could recognise urban policing as a central site of border control.

5. List of references

- AIDA (Asylum Information Database), & ECRE (European Council on Refugees and Exiles). (2025). Asylum Information Database | European Council on Refugees and Exiles in Spain. *Asylum Information Database*
<https://asylumineurope.org/reports/country/spain/detention-asylum-seekers/general/>
- Bauman, Z. (2016). *Strangers at Our Door*. Polity Press.
- Bazurli, R., & Castelli Gattinara, P. (2025). The Far Right Out of Its Comfort Zone? Framing Opposition to Immigration during COVID-19 in Italy. *Government and Opposition*, 60, 539–559. <https://doi.org/10.1017/gov.2024.20>
- Franko, K. (2019). *The Crimmigrant Other: Migration and Penal Power*. Routledge.
<https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351001441>
- Global Detention Project. (2022). *Spain: Covid-19 and Detention*. Mapping Immigration Detention around the World. <https://www.globaldetentionproject.org/countries>
- Kalir, B. (2023). Qualifying deportation: How police translation of ‘dangerous foreign criminals’ led to expansive deportation practices in Spain. *Security Dialogue*, 54(6), 548–567. <https://doi.org/10.1177/09670106221118798>
- López Sala, A. M., & Barbero, I. (2019). Solidarity under siege: The crimmigration of activism(s) and protest against border control in Spain. *European Journal of Criminology*, 18(5), 678–694. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1477370819882908>
- Moffette, D. (2020). The jurisdictional games of immigration policing: Barcelona’s fight against unauthorized street vending. *Theoretical Criminology*, 24(2), 258–275.
<https://doi.org/10.1177/1362480618811693>
- Planas Gifra, L. (2024). Securitizing migration in times of crisis: Private actors and the provision of (in)security. *Cogent Social Sciences*, 10(1), 2296601.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/23311886.2023.2296601>
- Racisme, S. O. S. (2022). SOS Racisme presenta l’informe ‘Pareu de parar-me. Vigilància 2.0 on denuncia la perfilació racial a Catalunya. *SOS Racisme*.

<https://sosracisme.org/la-policia-identifica-tres-vegades-mes-les-persones-estrangeres-que-les-autoctones/>

Ryo, E., Chacón, J. M., & Menjívar, C. (2025). Criminalization of Immigration. *RSF: The Russell Sage Foundation Journal of the Social Sciences*, 11(3), 282.

<https://doi.org/10.7758/RSF.2025.11.3.07>

Saez, S. (2017). *Spanish migrant detention centers 'worse than prisons'*.

<https://www.infomigrants.net/fr/post/6473/spanish-migrant-detention-centers-worse-than-prisons>

Sergi, A. (2020). Policing the port, watching the city. Manifestations of organised crime in the port of Genoa. *Policing and Society*, 31, 1–17.

<https://doi.org/10.1080/10439463.2020.1758103>

Servicio Jesuita a Migrantes (SJM). (2023). *Internamiento 'muteado'*. <https://sjme.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/06/Informe-CIE-2023-SJM.pdf>

StateWatch. (2021). *Statewatch | The Canary cage: The making of deportation islands on Spain's Atlantic border*. StateWatch. <https://www.statewatch.org/analyses/2021/the-canary-cage-the-making-of-deportation-islands-on-spain-s-atlantic-border/>

Stumpf, J. (2006). The Crimmigration Crisis: Immigrants, Crime, and Sovereign Power. *American University Law Review*, 56(2).

<https://digitalcommons.wcl.american.edu/aulr/vol56/iss2/3>

Stumpf, J. P. (2023). *Crimmigration and the Legitimacy of Immigration Law* (SSRN Scholarly Paper No. 4775490). Social Science Research Network.

<https://papers.ssrn.com/abstract=4775490>

Triviño-Salazar, J. C. (2020). *Covid-19, Barcelona y las personas inmigrantes: ¿La ciudad como refugio en tiempos de incertidumbre?* openDemocracy.

<https://www.opendemocracy.net/es/democraciaabierta-es/covid-19-barcelona-y-las-personas-inmigrantes-la-ciudad-como-refugio-en-tiempos-de-incertidumbre/>

- Tsiganou, J., Chalkia, A., & Lempesi, M. (2021). COVID-19 Crisis as the New-State-of-the-Art in the Crimmigration Milieu. *Social Sciences*, 10(12), 457.
<https://doi.org/10.3390/socsci10120457>
- van der Woude, M., & van der Leun, J. (2017). Crimmigration checks in the internal border areas of the EU: Finding the discretion that matters. *European Journal of Criminology*, 14(1), 27–45. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1477370816640139>
- Weber, L., & McCulloch, J. (2019). Penal power and border control: Which thesis? Sovereignty, governmentality, or the pre-emptive state? *Punishment & Society*, 21(4), 496–514. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1462474518797293>
- Wonders, N. A. (2017). Sitting on the fence – Spain’s delicate balance: Bordering, multiscale challenges, and crimmigration. *European Journal of Criminology*, 14(1), 7–26. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1477370816640140>
- Ziati, H., Dedeu, A., Ziati, N., & Soria, M. (2021). Identificaciones policiales por perfil racial. Estudio criminológico sobre las experiencias de identificación en España en 2020-2021. *Revista Logos, Ciencia & Tecnología*, 14, 41–56.
<https://doi.org/10.22335/rlct.v14i1.1487>